

Grown-up's Playbook: Athena's Little Owl

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Athena's Little Owl: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle, kindly tale, and no one in it is ever truly hurt or frightened for long.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Olive Town.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Wits** (clever thinking), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Heart** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out a prop or two if you can: anything small and soft to stand in for Glaux the owl, and a feather or a scrap of paper or two for her trail. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**.

When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Wits and Heart together, say, or Courage and Wits).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed.

Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. In these hills, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll

Twist of Fate

1	A friendly satyr gives you one free hint.
2	You find your courage again, and take back one energy star.
3	A favourable wind, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	Chiron the centaur passes by and nods kindly. All is well.
5	An olive branch for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A burst of birdsong, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

There is no foe in this tale at all, only a small lost owl and the kindness it takes to bring her home. The adventure is won by helping Glaux feel safe, choosing the true path with sharp eyes, and giving the tired little owl a gentle hand up to her perch. Let the children lead with care; that is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

Athena's Little Owl: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward cleverness and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Foggy Square (Easy)

The challenge. Glaux the owl is too frightened to be carried. The players must help her feel safe enough to trust them and hop onto a waiting hand.

Intended solution. This is a Heart and Observation moment. The kind move is to slow right down: lower their voices, move gently, hold still, and let the owl come to them rather than grabbing for her. Holding out a steady hand and waiting works beautifully.

Fallback. If the children rush and Glaux hops away, have Daphne hum a soft tune, or let a player spend an energy star to sit quietly until the owl creeps closer. Any gentle idea wins her trust and tops up an energy star.

Stop 2: The Whispering Paths (Normal)

The challenge. Three paths climb into the fog and all look the same. The players must find the one that leads to Athena's temple.

Intended solution. This is an Observation and Logic moment. The clever move is to look down and follow the trail of soft grey feathers Glaux shed as she fell. Asking **Bramble the Satyr** for a hint, or letting the owl herself turn her head toward home, works just as well.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have Bramble pop up and point the way with a joke, or let them spend an energy star to spot the feathers in the mist. Getting through with help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The High Perch (Normal)

The challenge. Glaux is tired and afraid to fly the last stretch up to her high marble perch through the mist. The players must help her up.

Intended solution. This is a Heart and Spatial moment. Any kind, gentle idea works: lifting a steady branch to bridge the gap, making a careful step for her small feet, or simply cheering her on until she finds the courage to flutter up. There is no wrong way to be kind here.

Fallback. If the children freeze, have Glaux give a small, hopeful hoot and lean toward them, and let a single encouraging word be enough. The moment they offer help of any kind, the little owl reaches her perch.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When Glaux is safely home, wise **Athena** opens her calm grey eyes, the morning fog lifts, and the sun pours warm and golden over the **Olive Town**. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being clever, brave, and kind.

Wits and Wonder

Grown-up's Playbook

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.